compared to $20.5 trillion for the United States.[10] With $2.2 trillion of exports in 2017, it is the world's largest export economy.[11] It has become the largest, second-largest, or third-largest trading partner of nearly every country in the world.[12] In 2015, China overtook Canada to become America's largest trade partner, with an astonishing $737 billion two-way trade in goods and services in 2018, and an equally massive $378.6 billion trade deficit.[13] From 2005 to 2017, Chinese firms invested approximately $170 billion in the United States.[14] With its heralded One Belt One Road (OBOR) initiative, supported by financial institutions like the new Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank and with $1 trillion in promised infrastructure investment across Eurasia, Beijing is bidding to reshape global trade and investment relations. Chinese giants like Baidu, Alibaba, and Tencent are now among the largest technology companies on earth, competing with Apple and Facebook, while Sinopec and China National Petroleum rank as the world's third- and fourth-largest corporations.[15]

All this economic wealth has not merely transformed life in China, it also has translated into usable national power. The People's Liberation Army (PLA), China's military, which includes its navy and air force, is now widely considered to be the second most powerful in the world, after the US armed forces. From a technologically inferior, largely defensive force in the 1980s, the PLA has become an increasingly high-tech military that is learning to project power far from its borders, primarily through its navy. It is also developing significant air power, space, and cyber capabilities. Chinese diplomacy complements its military influence, with Beijing hosting major international gatherings, participating more vocally in global institutions, and playing a role in high-profile diplomatic initiatives, such as the Six Party Talks, over North Korea's nuclear program. Chinese citizens are a now-common sight around the world, as Chinese students and researchers flood Western, especially American, universities. In the United States alone, over 350,000 Chinese enrolled in US institutions in 2016–17, accounting for over a third of all foreign students.[16] Just as ubiquitous are Chinese tourists, who have become a major factor in the global tourism industry,